Chapter 1: The Court of Minstrels isn't a Trial

The court of minstrels met twice a year, and every minstrel of any guild was required to come to it or have his license to be a minstrel taken away.

It was a beautiful day with the sun shining and a soft breeze blowing as Isaac made his way through the crowd of men dressed in colorful clothing with diamond patches and proceeded to the amphitheater for instruction, knowing exactly what to expect, as he'd been to the court of minstrels many times with his father.

First, the minstrels all came to the amphitheater where Jaunty, the personal jester to King Hadell, would give them instruction. Jaunty was a lanky jester, with rather sharp features that gave him a look of confidence. Of course, confidence was not his problem. He had confidence in spades.

After his instruction, they would break up into guilds and go around to different bards and minstrels to learn songs and stories to spread.

Isaac sat on a bench, waiting. Many of the minstrels were talking to each other, and he generally would join in. After all, he knew many of them. The minstrels in his guild, The Troubadours, were very friendly, and all knew each other well.

Isaac felt at home in his guild, but wasn't as comfortable with the minstrels from some of the other guilds. They Mystic Wolves were definitely into mysticism, and the Paragon Shadows did a great deal of dealing in the dark.

He was watching a minstrel who dressed in all black and wore a mask and hood as another minstrel came and sat beside him. "Hungry?" he asked, holding out some jerky. "Sorry about your father."

Isaac took the jerky, as he knew the minstrel well and trusted him, but didn't get to say anything back but a quick grunt of "Thanks, Noah," because everyone had to get quiet because Jaunty stood up in front of the crowd.

Everyone cheered for Jaunty, some enthusiastically and some only because they feared punishment if they didn't, but all minstrels were good at faking excitement as they had to perform even when they'd had a bad day.

"Welcome, minstrels!" Jaunty called out. "We have much to learn today. The job of a minstrel is important, as we tell people what to think and how to live. We determine values, morals, and beliefs of society. We spread news, but so much more.

"The people need us now, as there is a rise in legends of the light magic and people returning to belief in it. The king and chief minister both want any rumors of light

magic debunked. It needs to be ridiculed and mocked, and any who say it is real humiliated."

Isaac listened with furrowed eyebrows. He didn't believe in light magic. That was mere legend, and minstrels were not to spread false legends. He'd heard some of them, how the Divine King had once roamed the earth and how he'd left when people turned against him, but he'd assured them some day his heir would return. Supposedly, there were signs of his birth and return, but no one really cared, as it was a made up story. Still, it seemed wrong to be being instructed to ridicule and humiliate people. That wasn't really Isaac's style. Minstrels were to spread news, tell stories, and entertain, not mock and ridicule.

Yet, he had little choice but to listen to Jaunty, as Jaunty could oust any of them from the business. All the guilds had to do what Jaunty instructed or their guild licenses would be revoked.

Jaunty, in a very animated manner, continued talking of the dangers of belief in light magic, as magic does not exist, and how belief in it will make people get hopes up that can't be achieved, so they work toward the impossible, wasting their lives, shriveling into nothingness, losing themselves to a futile cause.

"Fools look at an empty sky and see a library of secrets," Jaunty mocked. "Don't allow people to trade their youth, their friends, and every real, warm thing for a handful of nothing. Magic is a ghost story told by those afraid of the dark and fools trying to build lanterns of parchment. I laugh at these men, as laughter is my job,

but I pity them too. They need your help to see reality."

Jaunty suddenly paused for dramatic effect and whispered, "All of you are to report any who talk of light magic to the knights. The lies they spread cause contention and division, ripping our kingdom from within, dividing our kingdom like a two-headed horse. In this case, with one half looking toward the law, and the other looking toward the clouds, each seeing the other as fools. One madman in a kingdom is comedy, but many is a graveyard. We must remain strong. People who mislead others must be punished."

Isaac really wanted to ask how the people would be punished as brutal scenes ran through his head, but knew better. Crossing Jaunty was never wise. He was counselor to both the king and chief minister, either of whom could call for someone's death.

A few other minstrels murmured agreement, or whispered dissent, but if anyone else wanted to question the directive, he wasn't brave enough to say anything either.

Isaac listened, as there was no choice but to, since he needed money, so he had to keep his license. Yet, something about Jaunty's speech just hit him wrong, like a false note in a well-rehearsed song.

Sure, Isaac was for countering the lies of light magic, and for trying to help the people believe in themselves, not mystic magic. Yet, punishing people for their beliefs or for speaking them just seemed wrong, like whipping a shadow for blocking the light. Minstrels were to spread news, to influence people's ideas, and to help them see

truth. Why should they fear opposing ideas? Truth has nothing to fear.

Jaunty finished his speech and taught the first song of the day:

"Myths are spread of magic spells, of kings divine, of light,
Of mystic magic, miracles, and lies said to be right.
It's King Hadell who holds the power over all the land,
And Rivkin, our chief minister, who's on the king's right hand.
Have faith in those you see and know. They're men who you can trust.
Obedience to their commands unquestioned is a must.
They care and know what's best for you. They're virtuous and wise.
Be loyal citizens for them. Trust them and not the lies.
Oh, King Hadell is god-like. Rivkin's powers all impress,
So worship them and see their grandeur. Both are true noblesse.
Noblesse obligues' their guiding rule, as leaders are to serve,
And in return, they don't ask much, just take what they deserve.
Make merry, dance, enjoy your priv'ledge, all that you are due.
But heed commands unquestioning, or fear what will ensue.

All rights and freedoms come from Rivkin, and Hadell, your king.
So, praise them for their mercy. Lift your voices now and sing.
Sing praises to your King Hadell. Sing praises to the chief,
And never question what they say. Give faith and blind belief.
They know what's best. They care for you. Deserving great applauds.
They're powerful and humble, men to worship as your gods."

The tune was catchy enough, and Isaac picked up the lyrics quickly. Sure, they were a little pompous, but nobility always was.

Isaac was a quick learner. He'd started as a minstrel young, as his father was a minstrel. They'd worked as a team until six months ago when his father died. His mother moved in with her sister on a farm on the northeast edge of Kyrios, near the sea.

Isaac wasn't interested in working on a farm on the outskirts of the city. He liked traveling, at least to most cities. Lefkon was cold, and Nisi required going over a long bridge or going by boat, and Isaac didn't like water. It was actually his biggest fear. Yet, he'd been to both cities. The only city he'd never gone to was Rylan, which wasn't considered one of the seven cities in the kingdom. Rylan was a small village on a southern island that could only be reached by boat. Beside his fear of water, minstrels were forbidden from going to the island. Technically, it was part of the kingdom, but Rylan

claimed independence, and stories of people going there and never returning were sung by minstrels. Isaac knew one.

Isaac learned the song they were being taught, and then went to his first lesson of the day. There were four lessons that day, and the minstrels were to rotate through them.

The first lesson Isaac attended was taught by Chief Minister Rivkin himself. He began by repeating the announcement that rumors had been arising of light magic and the return of the Divine King coming soon, that those needed to be countered, and that anyone finding who was spreading them was to turn them in.

Isaac wanted to say something, but knew better, so he sat, tensing his lips to keep quiet.

Rivkin asked the minstrels what they had heard about the Divine King and light magic.

“I heard the Divine King was born thirty years ago and is to return soon when the queen’s shield is restored,” one man called out.

“That is the lie that is spreading,” Rivkin replied. “Light magic does not exist. No magic exists. I do have powers, but it is not magic. It is science.”

“What about the queen’s shield?” another minstrel asked. “There are those who believe the shield in the courtyard by the chapel is the shield of legend.”

“It’s not,” Rivkin assured him. “There never was a magical queen’s shield. Yes, a queen years ago used a shield, as she was paranoid about someone trying to kill her, but the shield was not magical. Yes, that is the shield

stuck in the pedestal. It cannot be moved. It will not fulfill any prophecy. Tell people, it belonged to a great warrior in battle."

"It has a panther on it," a minstrel pointed out. "That is the sign of a loving mother who has a sweet and loving nature toward her young and protects them. No one will believe a strong warrior had it."

Rivkin thought for a moment and suggested, "We can say the warrior used it in honor of his mother who died young. That is noble."

Isaac almost spoke up. The words rising in his throat, but he choked them down. "We can say…" bothered him. Was it right to say something that they did not know? Making something up like that was just a flat out lie.

"That is the story everyone will spread," Rivkin insisted. "The shield belonged to a warrior, and it was put on a pedestal to honor him. Perhaps you can all make up a song about it. Since we need to get facts consistent, let's say he fought against the kingdom of Valste in the war a hundred years ago."

"Isn't that lying?" Isaac muttered, the words slipping through his lips before his mind could stop them.

He was surprised that Rivkin heard him and replied, "No, it is protecting the people from false ideologies. We do not know the origin of the shield, only that it did belong to a former queen. Yet, that story will make rumors fly and encourage the fools who believe in light magic. Telling people this story, which may be true, is for them, to protect them. It's for their own good."

"I see," Isaac replied with a tight smile. He'd heard

the idea of telling stories for the good of the people before and never questioned it, but this one seemed like a flat out lie – not filling in possible details or stretching the truth. Rivkin had just admitted the shield belonged to a queen, but to say it belonged to a warrior.

The lesson continued. Rivkin explained how to respond to people who believed in light magic and reminded the minstrels to turn them in, for their own good, so they could be taught the truth. After all, their fantasies might make them feel good, but they would crash, so they had to know the truth.

Every muscle in Isaac's body screamed for him to stay silent, and his mind insisted he was a fool if he did not, but he mastered his fear and finally asked, as calmly as he could, "What punishment do you intend for those we turn in?"

Rivkin nodded politely back and calmly explained, "They will be conditioned to believe the truth. If they are wise and choose to believe it, they will be returned home. Otherwise, they will be put in the dungeon or executed."

The dungeon… Executed… The words hung in the air like a death sentence, cold and utterly wrong, and the casual cruelty which Rivkin said it with churned Isaac's stomach as a physical blow. Isaac fought the urge to argue, but instead calmly ask, "Isn't that over-reacting? People believing in some Divine King is harmless."

In a sugary tone, Rivkin explained, "No, it's not. As rulers of the kingdom, the king and I must do whatever it takes to ensure the stability and prosperity of the kingdom. That means we must be obeyed without

question. We must maintain our power, or we cannot help the people. We need to be revered, seen as having compassion, integrity, and religious devotion. Yet, at times, we must do what needs to be done, even if it seems harsh. If the people fear us, that is fine. Fear is a better motivator for people to obey than love."

Isaac stared at him, his stomach still uneasy and his mind unsure what to think. Ruling a kingdom had to be hard, but still, was it right to punish people because they believed in some fake Divine King?

"Feelings must be put aside," Rivkin explained. "At times morals do too. A noble end is worth any means."

Isaac nodded, not in agreement, but surrendering to the harsh reality that arguing could get him expelled from the guild, or worse, a walk to the gallows.

Rivkin then addressed everyone in the group. "The believers of the Divine King are becoming bolder. They must be stopped. You are to encourage anyone who knows of any believers to report them to us. The people need to be good citizens and help us help the people who have such false beliefs."

Help them? Help them by coercing them to think the way the chief minister wants them to? That just felt so wrong to Isaac, like breaking a bird's wings and then praising it for staying it its cage. And how is it being a good citizen to have people turn in their neighbors for what they think?

He wished his father was still around. Everything was so straight-forward and exciting with his father. Since his father's death, life was confusing. Even coming to the

court of minstrels wasn't what it normally was. Perhaps that was because of his father not being there, but it was different anyway. Never before had they been told to report people or encourage other people to." He ran his fingers through his light brown hair. Perhaps they had, and he didn't listen, as he had always had his father there before, but he didn't think so.

Something odd was going on, really odd. The big question was what?

Isaac had a hard time focusing, as he kept trying to sort out his thoughts.

At the end of the lesson, Rivkin walked up to him. A cold chill ran through Issac's blood, as the thought of the comment that slipped before ran through his mind. Whatever Rivkin was coming to say would not be good.

It wasn't. Rivkin had sharp features, dark hair that fell past his shoulders, dark eyes, and towering height. He glared down at Isaac, who was very average height, and insisted, "You will do as instructed."

Every muscle in Isaac's body tensed, and he barely got out the words through a tight throat, "Of course."

Rivkin's glare became more burning as he hissed, "Do not question any commands given. Obey fully, or you might end up as your father."

His father? His father had died of an accident… At least that's what he was told. Was it?

Isaac looked away for a moment, but then took a breath and met Rivkin's eyes. "Are you implying my father's death wasn't an accident?"

Rivkin's chuckle in response sent shivers of fear

down Isaac’s spine.

“It was an accident,” Rivkin hissed, the sound low, scraping, and sliding out with a cold, smooth venom. He leaned over, trapping Issac under the weight of his burning stare. “Accidents happen all the time to people who question my command.”